



Battle Of Gettysburg

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Introduction: Battle of Gettysburg

The Battle of Gettysburg took place from July 1 to July 3, 1863. The battle took place in Gettysburg, Pennsylvania located in Adams County and is considered to be one of the most important engagements of the American Civil War.



Lee's Invasion of the North

In 1863, after winning a big battle at Chancellorsville, General Robert E. Lee felt confident and decided to invade the North again. He wanted to take the fighting out of Virginia, help other Confederate troops under attack, and maybe convince Britain and France to support the South. Around the same time, President Abraham Lincoln was unhappy with his Union general, Joseph Hooker, so he replaced him with General George Meade. Meade quickly led the Union army north to chase Lee's 75,000 soldiers into Maryland and Pennsylvania, which led directly to the Battle of Gettysburg.



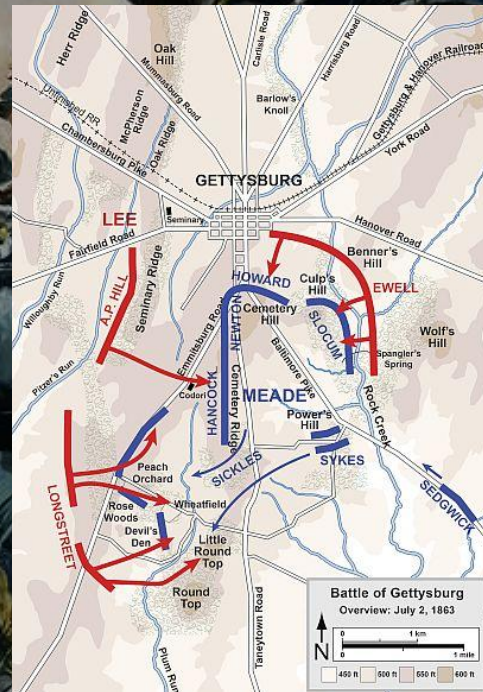
Battle of Gettysburg: Day 1

In early July 1863, General Robert E. Lee wanted to gather his Confederate army near the town of Gettysburg, Pennsylvania. On July 1, some of his men went there looking for supplies but ran into Union cavalry that had arrived first. As more soldiers from both sides moved toward the area, Confederate troops pushed the smaller Union force back through the town to a strong defensive spot on Cemetery Hill. Lee told General Richard Ewell he could attack the hill if he thought it was possible, but Ewell decided not to because the Union position looked too strong, and people later criticized him for not being aggressive like Stonewall Jackson. By that evening and overnight, more Union corps arrived and reinforced a long defensive line from Cemetery Hill down Cemetery Ridge to a hill called Little Round Top, setting up a solid position for the fighting to come.



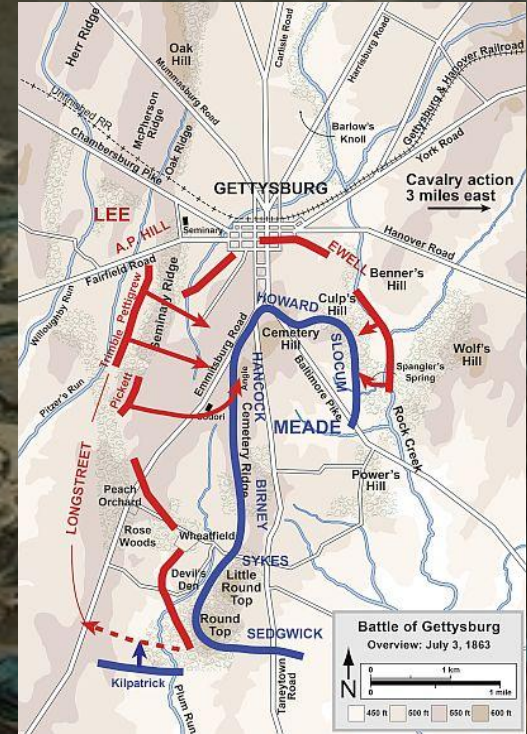
Battle of Gettysburg: Day 2

On July 2, the second day of the Battle of Gettysburg, the Union army held strong defensive positions from Culp's Hill to Cemetery Ridge. Robert Lee decided to attack these positions, even though his second-in-command, James Longstreet, preferred to stay on defense. Lee ordered Longstreet to attack the Union left and General Richard Ewell to attack the Union right near Culp's Hill. Longstreet did not start his assault until about 4 p.m., when his troops clashed with Union forces under General Daniel Sickles in areas like Devil's Den, a peach orchard, a wheat field, and the slopes of Little Round Top. Union soldiers, including a tough Maine regiment, managed to hold Little Round Top but lost Devil's Den, the orchard, and the wheat field, and Sickles was badly wounded. Ewell's attack on Culp's Hill and East Cemetery Hill was also stopped by Union defenders by nightfall. By the end of the day, both sides had suffered very heavy losses, with over 9,000 casualties each and nearly 35,000 total in the first two days of fighting.



Battle of Gettysburg: Day 3

On the morning of July 3, Union troops recaptured and secured Culp's Hill after hours of fighting. Believing victory was close, General Lee ordered about 15,000 men, including George Pickett's division, to attack the Union center on Cemetery Ridge. Around 3 p.m., they advanced across open fields in what became known as Pickett's Charge, but Union soldiers fired from the front and sides, devastating the attack. Fewer than half of the Confederate soldiers returned, and Pickett's division lost most of its men, forcing Lee and Longstreet to repair their weakened defensive line.



Impact of the Battle of Gettysburg

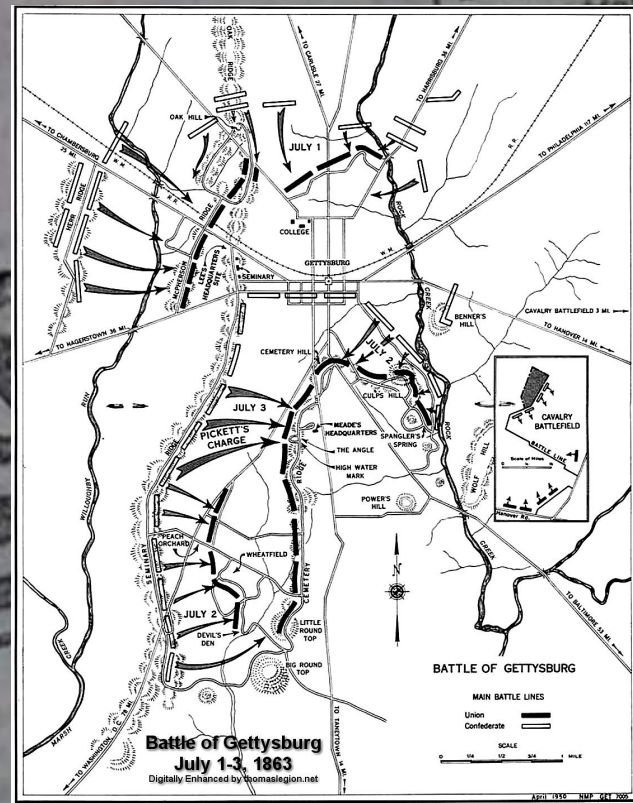
After his failed attack at Gettysburg, General Lee's invasion of the North collapsed, and he retreated to Virginia on the night of July 4. The battle was a major Union victory, with about 23,000 Union and 28,000 Confederate casualties, over a third of Lee's army. The South lost hope for foreign support, and although Lee offered to resign, he stayed in command. Gettysburg, along with Grant's victory at Vicksburg, turned the Civil War in favor of the Union.

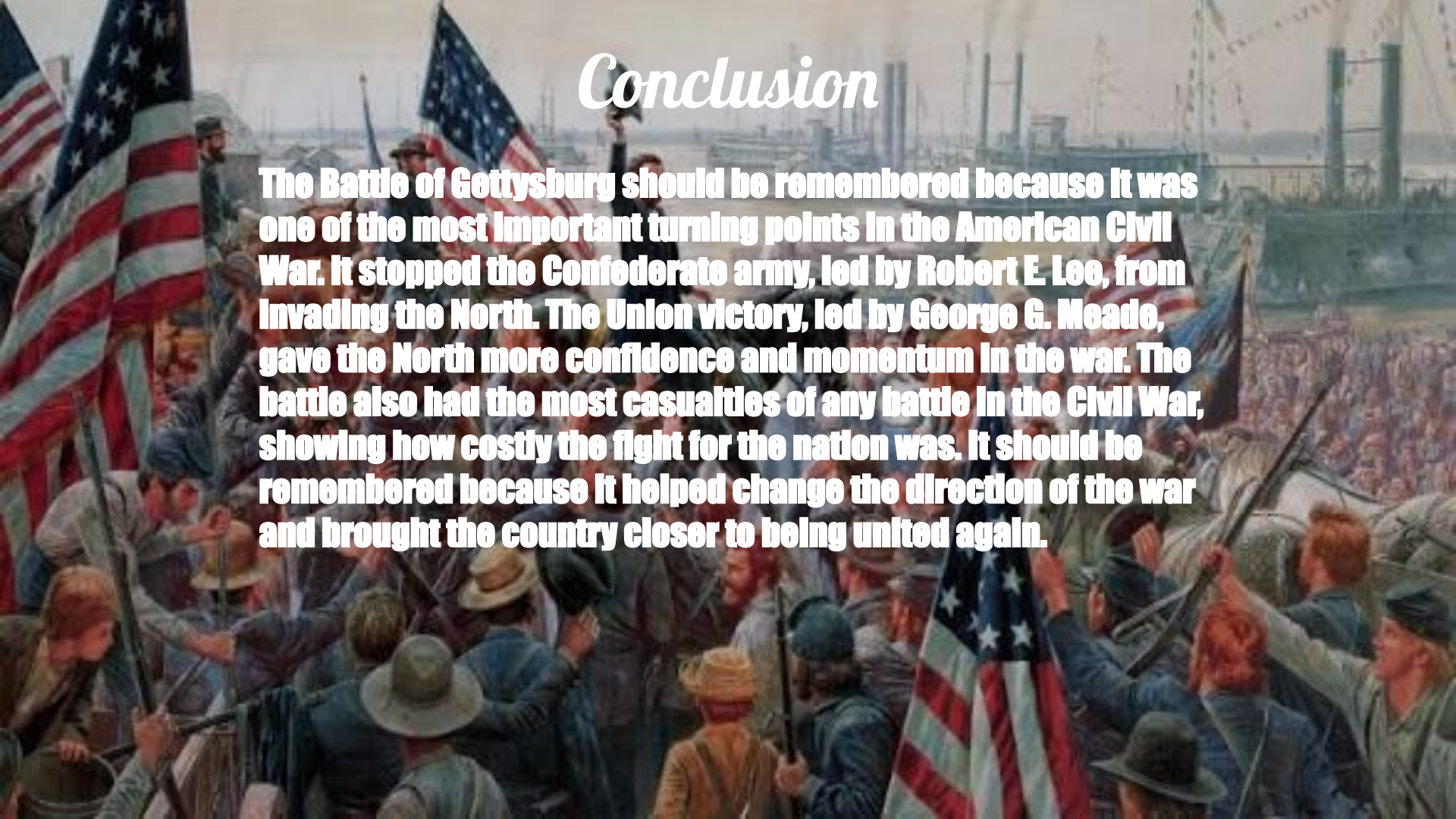
THE BATTLE OF GETTYSBURG, PA. JULY 3RD 1863.

This terrific and bloody conflict between the gallant Army of the Potomac, commanded by their great General George G. Meade, and the hosts of the rebel Army of the East

Multimedia

BATTLE OF GETTYSBURG





Conclusion

The Battle of Gettysburg should be remembered because it was one of the most important turning points in the American Civil War. It stopped the Confederate army, led by Robert E. Lee, from invading the North. The Union victory, led by George G. Meade, gave the North more confidence and momentum in the war. The battle also had the most casualties of any battle in the Civil War, showing how costly the fight for the nation was. It should be remembered because it helped change the direction of the war and brought the country closer to being united again.

Cites

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